



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

waters, so the idea is to get back into the World Championship — the pinnacle of motorsport and rallying — to showcase both our skill and our product.

How does WRC2 compare to the rallying formats you've dominated in India and Asia-Pacific?

It doesn't differ too much from the Asia-Pacific, apart from being a lot longer. But on the world level, there is absolutely no comparison because the cars we drive there are on a different level.

They use proper World Rally Cars — faster, more powerful, and non-production ones that are specifically built for these events. The cars here are pretty much production cars (modifying standard vehicles).

The other main difference is that those rallies last four days, while in

India they span barely a day and a half — sometimes even less — due to the lack of available distance. Over there, we cover more than 2,000 kilometres, whereas here, it's usually closer to 300.

What's the biggest challenge when you step onto the global platform?

It's very different now compared to five or seven years ago [when he made his international debut]. People have very big budgets; they do nearly 20 to 25 rallies a year. They practise every weekend of the year because they have their own equipment and cars.

That's what puts India on the back foot because, in my case, I don't have that much funding to compete. Yet, I just set my goals, and I don't complain about it. I see it as another opportunity to go and make my mark.

Rallying in India goes back decades, with many legendary drivers coming to the fore. The number of events is increasing as well. What makes rally racing click here?

Rallying has always been the pioneer of motorsport in India. People were more inclined towards it because there were fewer racetracks in the country, with the prominent ones being in the South.

Naturally, that meant more people in the North opted for off-road races.

That's why, in the past, most of the top rallies and rally drivers were from the North.

We have the Himalayan rallies, the ones in the desert, and so many others, which were more difficult because of the terrain and region. It automatically became a more popular sport.